

The Gentle Clue Hunt Adventure

Little adventurers • 3-4 years old



Lily, Mina, and Joy were three. They were small, quick, and full of “What’s that?” and “Why?”

This morning the sun made bright squares on the living room rug. The rug looked like a garden of soft colors.

Lily held a little basket. Mina wore a paper crown. Joy carried a chunky blue crayon like it was a wand.

“Let’s have a big adventure,” said Lily.

“In our house?” Mina asked.

“Yes,” said Joy. “House adventures are the best. Because snacks are close.”

They all giggled.

Lily leaned close and whispered, “We can make a clue game.”

“A clue game?” Mina’s eyes grew round.

“Yes,” Lily said. “We hide tiny clues. Then we find them. Like brave explorers.”

Joy nodded very hard. “We can do it. We are smart. We are strong. We are three!”

They sat on the rug and thought. Thinking was their first brave act.

Mina tapped her chin. “We need rules.”

Lily said, “Rule one: Be gentle.”

Joy added, “Rule two: No stepping on plants.”

Mina looked around. “But we have no plants here.”

Joy pointed to the windowsill. A small pot held a little green plant with shiny leaves.

“The leaf baby,” Joy said softly. “We must respect it.”

Lily nodded. “Rule three: We only look. We don’t pull.”

They all said together, “Only look. Don’t pull.”

Lily opened the basket. Inside were three things: a smooth pinecone, a tiny wooden spoon, and a small red ribbon.

“These are our treasure clues,” Lily said.

Mina clapped. “Pinecone! Spoon! Ribbon!”

Joy held up her crayon. “And we need clue pictures. I can draw.”

They decided Joy would draw, Mina would hide, and Lily would be the first finder. Then they would switch. That felt fair, and fairness felt warm.

Joy took three little cards from a box. On the first card she drew a picture of a window with a smiling sun. On the second she drew a picture of a chair. On the third she drew a picture of a book.

Her drawings were wiggly and wonderful.

Mina tiptoed away with the pinecone, spoon, and ribbon. She hummed a hiding song: “Hidey-hide, safe and small, not too high, not to fall.”

Lily waited on the rug and practiced being patient. She held her hands together. She counted softly. “One... two... three... four...”

Joy sat beside Lily. “Waiting is brave,” Joy said.

Lily smiled. "I am brave. I can wait."

Mina came back with a proud face. "Ready!"

Joy gave Lily the first card with the sunny window.

Lily held it close. "Window," she said. "I know a window."

They walked together to the window. The glass shone like quiet water. Outside, a tree waved its leaves.

Lily saw the little plant on the sill. "Hello, leaf baby," she whispered.

They looked gently around it. Behind the pot, not touching the soil, was the red ribbon.

"I found it!" Lily said, softly but bright.

Mina clapped. "Good finding!"

Joy said, "We did not pull the plant. We only looked."

Lily tied the ribbon around her wrist like a tiny flag. "Respect," she said, even though the word was big. It felt like a hug.

Joy handed Lily the second card. It showed a chair.

"The chair!" Lily said. "To the chair mountain!"

The chair was big and brown and very normal. But today it was Chair Mountain. They climbed with careful knees and safe hands. Lily did not jump. Mina did not push. Joy watched like a kind captain.

Under the chair, on the floor, waited the wooden spoon.

Lily picked it up. "Spoon treasure!"

Mina nodded. "You were clever. You looked under."

Joy said, "And you were calm. Calm is strong."

Now Joy gave Lily the third card, the one with the book.

Lily marched to the bookshelf. It was tall, but Lily was small. She could not reach the top shelf.

Her mouth turned down for a moment. "It's too high."

Mina touched Lily's arm. "We can help. We are a team."

Joy looked around. "We can use the little stool. The safe stool."

The stool was low and sturdy. They carried it together. They made slow steps. No rushing. No bumping.

Lily stood on the stool. Mina held the stool with both hands. Joy held Lily's waist gently, like a seatbelt made of friendship.

"Ready," Joy said. "You can do it."

Lily took a deep breath. "I can do hard things."

She looked at the books. She did not pull them out. She did not bend pages. She just peeked with her eyes.

Behind a big picture book, she saw the pinecone.

"There!" Lily said.

She reached carefully and lifted it out.

"I got it!" Lily's voice bounced like a happy ball.

Mina cheered. Joy cheered. Even the leaf baby seemed to shine.

They went back to the rug with all the treasures. Lily put them in the basket.

"Now we switch," Mina said. "My turn to find!"

Joy nodded. "And Lily can hide."

Lily hid the treasures in new places. She chose gentle places. She did not hide anything near water. She did not hide anything on the stairs. She did not hide anything near the leaf baby.

She whispered to the plant, "We keep you safe."

Joy drew new clue cards: a sink with bubbles, a couch with a pillow, and a door with a mat.

Mina found the spoon by the couch pillow. She found the ribbon near the doormat. Then she looked at the sink clue and frowned.

"The sink is wet," Mina said. "Wet can be slippery."

Lily nodded. "Good thinking."

Joy pointed. "Look beside the sink, not inside."

Mina looked beside the sink and found the pinecone resting on a dry towel. She beamed.

"I was careful," Mina said.

"Yes," Lily said. "Careful is brave too."

When everyone had a turn, they made a tiny “nature thank-you” moment. Lily held the pinecone and said, “Thank you, tree.”

Mina held the ribbon and said, “Thank you, wind, for waving it.”

Joy held the spoon and said, “Thank you, wood, for being strong.”

Then they put the pinecone by the window for a while, like a guest. They watered the leaf baby with a few careful drops.

“No splashing,” Joy reminded.

“No pulling,” Mina added.

“Only love,” Lily finished.

The sun squares on the rug grew soft and sleepy. The big house adventure was done, and the house was still the same house. But it felt a little more magical.

Lily yawned. Mina yawned. Joy yawned.

Joy whispered, “Tomorrow we can make a new clue game.”

Mina smiled. “With new pictures.”

Lily hugged the basket. “And we will be brave explorers again.”

They sat close, warm and safe, listening to the quiet sounds of home. Outside, the tree kept waving. Inside, three little girls felt proud, peaceful, and ready for dreams.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) What are the names of the three girls?

- Lily, Mina and Joy
- Lily, Anna and May
- Sara, Mina and Joy
- Tom, Bob and Joy

2) Where did they have the big adventure?

- In the house
- In the forest
- At school
- At the park

3) What must they not pull?

- The leaf baby
- The ribbon
- The spoon
- The pinecone

4) What did Joy use to draw the clue pictures?

- A crayon
- A paint brush
- A computer
- A ball

Correct answers:

1) Lily, Mina and Joy 2) In the house 3) The leaf baby 4) A crayon

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Adventure: A fun trip or game where you explore and try new things at home or outside.

Basket: A container with sides you can carry to put toys or treasures inside.

Crown: A make-believe hat that sits on the head, like a king or queen wears.

Crayon: A colored stick you use to draw and make pictures on paper.

Explorers: People who look for new places or hidden things, like curious children searching.

Gentle: To touch or move something softly so it does not get hurt or broken.

Patient: To wait calmly without getting upset when you want something right away.

Captain: A leader who watches and helps others stay safe and do the right thing.

Stool: A small, low seat you can stand on to reach something higher safely.

Bookshelf: A piece of furniture with flat spaces to hold and organize books.

Pinecone: A hard, scaly seed pod from a tree, often brown and cone shaped.

Ribbon: A thin, soft strip of cloth used to tie or decorate things.

Towel: A cloth you use to dry hands, dishes, or to keep things dry.

Careful: To do things slowly and safely so nothing gets broken or someone hurt.

Respect: To treat people, animals, and things kindly and not hurt them.

Brave: To try something even when you feel a little scared, and keep going.